

Fachhochschule Hagenberg



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Chlorophyll Determination

Determination of Chlorophyll in Biomatter using
Spectrophotometry

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1 Background

1.1 Hemoglobin

Hemoglobin Hb is a vital oxygen-carrying protein found in red blood cells. It consists of four subunits:

- 2x α -chains
- 2x β -chains

Each chain contains a heme group with a central iron ion in the ferrous state Fe^{2+} , which is responsible for binding oxygen.

1.2 Methemoglobin

When the iron in Hb is oxidized to the ferric state Fe^{3+} , it forms methemoglobin MetHb, which cannot bind oxygen and therefore cannot participate in oxygen transport.

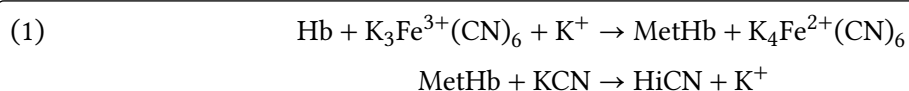
The oxidation of Hb to MetHb is a normal process, but the human body tries to keep the amount of MetHb at $< 1\%$ of the total Hb. Enzymes in red blood cells (like NADPH methemoglobin reductase) continuously reduce the iron back to Fe^{2+} to regenerate functional hemoglobin. However, if someone is exposed to certain oxidizing agents (for example, nitrates in well water, benzocaine, or dapsone), the rate of $\text{Fe}^{2+} \rightarrow \text{Fe}^{3+}$ conversion can overwhelm the repair enzymes.

The result is methemoglobinemia, where a significant fraction of hemoglobin is stuck in the Fe^{3+} form. Blood with high methemoglobin turns a chocolate-brown color and can cause symptoms of hypoxia (like cyanosis, fatigue or even neurological symptoms at very high levels)

1.3 Hemiglobincyanide Method

To measure the concentration of hemoglobin in blood samples, one reliable laboratory method is the hemiglobincyanide HiCN method, also known as the cyanmethemoglobin method. This technique converts all forms of hemoglobin (except sulfhemoglobin) into a single, stable colored complex, cyanmethemoglobin = hemiglobincyanide, which can be measured photometrically. This approach is recommended by the World Health Organization (WHO) due to its high accuracy and reproducibility.

The conversion is achieved using Drabkin's reagent, which contains potassium ferricyanide $\text{K}_3\text{Fe}(\text{CN})_6$ and potassium cyanide KCN. Equation 1 describes: The ferricyanide oxidizes hemoglobin to MetHb, and the cyanide then binds to MetHb to form HiCN.



The resulting HiCN complex is stable and has a specific absorbance peak at wavelengths around 540 – 546nm. This property allows for photometric measurement of hemoglobin concentration using a spectrophotometer. Finally the hemoglobin concentration is determined based on the Beer–Lambert law, shown in Equation 2.

$$(2) \quad A = \epsilon * c * \ell$$

A ... total absorbance
 ϵ ... molar absorptivity of the substance
 c ... concentration of substance in the sample
 ℓ ... path length through sample

1.4 Reflotron Method

An alternative method for hemoglobin determination is the Reflotron system, a point-of-care device that uses dry reagent strips and reflectance photometry. A drop of whole blood is applied to a test strip, and the device measures the color intensity reflected from the strip to calculate hemoglobin concentration. While the Reflotron provides rapid and user-friendly results, the HiCN method remains the gold standard due to its accuracy and standardization.

2 Procedure

Due to unfortunate circumstances, the Reflotron during our lab session was defective and therefore no test data using that method could be collected. As a result, this chapter only covers the hemiglobincyanide method.

2.1 Materials

- Fresh blood sample (capillary or venous)
- Drabkin's reagent (contains $\text{K}_3\text{Fe}(\text{CN})_6$ and KCN)
- Spectrophotometer with a 546 nm filter
- Cuvettes
- Pipettes and tips
- Gloves, lab coat, protective eyewear

2.2 Safety Notes

Always wear gloves and handle blood as a biohazard.

Drabkin's reagent contains potassium cyanide, a highly potent neurotoxin. Prevent inhalation or other absorption of the substance. Be mindful of proper waste disposal.

2.3 Steps

1. Prepare sample and reference cuvettes.
 1. Fill both cuvettes with 5mL of Drabkin's reagent.
 2. Add 20 μ L of blood to the sample cuvette.
2. Gently shake the sample cuvette to mix the contents.
3. Incubate for ≥ 5 minutes in the dark for full conversion to cyan-methemoglobin HiCN.
4. Set the spectrophotometer to 546 nm.
5. Zero the device using the reference cuvette.
6. Insert the sample cuvette and record the absorbance ($E_{546} = A$).
7. Calculate the hemoglobin concentration using Equation 6.

2.4 Calculation of Hemoglobin Concentration

2.4.1 Seemingly wrong formula

Using the Beer-Lambert law from Equation 2 we formulate:

$$(3) \quad c [\text{mol/L}] = \frac{A}{\varepsilon} \times \frac{1}{\ell}$$

We can calculate our absorptivity ε of HiCN for the total sample:

$$\begin{aligned}
 (4) \quad \epsilon_{\text{total}} &= \frac{\epsilon_{\text{HiCN}}}{M_{\text{G}_{\text{Hb}}}} \times \frac{V_{\text{probe}}}{V_{\text{total}}} \\
 &= \frac{44\,000 \frac{\text{L}}{\text{mol} \cdot \text{cm}}}{64\,458 \frac{\text{g}}{\text{mol}}} \times \frac{20\,\mu\text{L}}{5.02\,\text{mL}} \\
 &\approx 0.272 \frac{\text{m}^2}{\text{kg}} = 2.72 \frac{\text{L}}{\text{kg} \cdot \text{cm}}
 \end{aligned}$$

This was calculated using the following values:

- molar absorptivity of HiCN: $\epsilon_{\text{HiCN}} = 44\,000 \frac{\text{L}}{\text{mol} \cdot \text{cm}}$
- molar mass of Hb: $M_{\text{G}_{\text{Hb}}} = 64\,458 \frac{\text{g}}{\text{mol}}$
- volume of the blood probe: $V_{\text{probe}} = 20\,\mu\text{L}$
- volume of the total sample: $V_{\text{total}} = 5.02\,\text{mL}$

Since we know that our cuvette has a thickness of $\ell = 1\text{cm}$ we can calculate the concentration of Hb in the sample:

$$\begin{aligned}
 (5) \quad c \text{ [kg/L]} &= \frac{A}{\epsilon_{\text{total}}} \times \frac{1}{\ell} \\
 &= \frac{A}{2.72 \frac{\text{L}}{\text{kg} \cdot \text{cm}}} \times \frac{1}{0.01\text{m}} \\
 &= A \times \frac{1}{2.72 \frac{\text{L}}{\text{kg} \cdot \text{cm}} \times 1\text{cm}} \\
 &= A \times \frac{1}{2.72} \frac{\text{kg}}{\text{L}} \\
 &\approx A \times 0.368 \frac{\text{kg}}{\text{L}} \\
 \Rightarrow c \text{ [g/dL]} &= A \times 36.77 \frac{\text{g}}{\text{dL}}
 \end{aligned}$$

2.4.2 Correct formula from instructor

The instructor provided us with a formula containing the precalculated factor to calculate the hemoglobin concentration:

$$(6) \quad c \text{ [g/dL]} = A \times 14.746 \frac{\text{g}}{\text{dL}}$$

We will use this factor in all further applications, even though there seems to be no explanation for the significant difference between the two formulas. Plugging in the values in their formula $A \times \frac{M_{\text{G}_{\text{Hb}}}}{\epsilon_{\text{HiCN}}} \times \frac{V_{\text{total}}}{V_{\text{probe}}} \times \frac{1}{d} \left[\frac{\text{g}}{\text{L}} \right]$ does not yield the same result for me.

Example calculation using placeholder values:

$$A = 1.21$$

$$c_{\text{Hb}} = 1.21 \times 14.746 \frac{\text{g}}{\text{dL}} = 17.843 \frac{\text{g}}{\text{dL}}$$

3 Results

We analyzed the data from

1. our class
2. the data of all years, ranging from 2015 to 2024

3.1 Our class: MBI24 (current year)

Table 1 shows the summary of our class. In total 22 students participated in the experiment, split between 12 females and 10 males. One can observe that the mean c_{Hb} of the females is lower than the mean of the males, and the range also suggests that the males hemoglobin concentration tends to be higher.

Group	Amount	Range ($\frac{\text{g}}{\text{dL}}$)	Mean $\pm$ SD ($\frac{\text{g}}{\text{dL}}$)	Variance
Male	10	10.9 – 23.0	16.7 ± 3.5	13.5
Female	12	10.1 – 17.3	12.1 ± 4.3	19.9

Table 1: MBI24 results summary male vs. female

We expect the difference in c_{Hb} between males and females to be statistically significant. Therefore we performed a two-sample t-test with different variances using an α of 5% to test the null hypothesis that the difference in c_{Hb} between males and females is zero.

The results of the test are shown in Table 2. The t-statistic is 2.63, the critical t-value is 1.72, the p-value is 0.81% and the Cohen's d is 0.32.

Since the p-value is less than the chosen $\alpha = 5\%$, we reject the null hypothesis and conclude that the difference in c_{Hb} between males and females is statistically significant. This is also supported by the t-statistic of 2.63 exceeding the critical t-value of 1.72.

The Cohen's d of 0.32 indicates a small effect size, which means that the difference in c_{Hb} between males and females is not very large.

Key Values	
chosen α	5%
t-statistic	2.63
critical t-value	1.72
p-value	0.81%
Cohen's d	0.32

Table 2: MBI24 t-test values

3.2 All years: 2015 - 2024

The analysis is repeated for the years 2015 to 2024 (including MBI24). The results are shown in Table 3. We can observe the same tendency as in Section 3.1 of a higher c_{Hb} in males than in females.

Group	Amount	Range ($\frac{\text{g}}{\text{dL}}$)	Mean $\pm$ SD ($\frac{\text{g}}{\text{dL}}$)	Variance
Male	117	2.32 – 53.2	16.72 ± 7.83	61.36
Female	126	0.37 – 59.8	14.87 ± 7.24	52.35

Table 3: All years results summary male vs. female

For this dataset we also performed a two-sample t-test with different variances using an α of 5%.

The results are shown in Table 4. The t-statistic is 1.66, the critical t-value is 1.65, the p-value is 4.98% and the Cohen's d is 0.026.

Since the p-value is less than the chosen $\alpha = 5\%$, we reject the null hypothesis and conclude that the difference in c_{Hb} between males and females is statistically significant. This is also supported by the t-statistic of 1.66 being slightly greater than the critical t-value of 1.65.

The Cohen's d of 0.026 indicates a very small effect size, which means that the difference in c_{Hb} between males and females is tiny.

Key Values	
chosen α	5%
t-statistic	1.66
critical t-value	1.65
p-value	4.98%
Cohen's d	0.026

Table 4: All years t-test values

This matches the intuitive interpretation of the data based on the boxplots seen in, where the observed difference is rather marginal.

3.3 Conclusion

The results of both t-tests show that the difference in c_{Hb} between males and females is statistically significant. This is also supported by the boxplots and the key values. We can observe less pronounced differences in the all years dataset, which can probably be attributed to the higher sample size and therefore more noise accumulation.

In Section 3.1 covering the class of the current year (MBI24), we can observe a significant difference in c_{Hb} between males and females, despite the comparatively small sample size. This indicates high accuracy of the hemiglobincyanide method.

Appendix

Sources